possible. And I would always wonder how Papaji was able to convince the maharaja.

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It doesn't take much to convince someone of anything if you actually mean what you say. Honesty, grit and determination can move mountains, and I had seen it. When the IO asked me why I wanted to join the Indian Air Force, I had a couple of answers ready for him. I could have sounded passionate; I could have sounded patriotic or even adamant, corny and desperate. But I knew why I had come for this. I knew what I wanted and why I wanted it. I knew what to tell them.

'I want to fly,' I replied without thinking it over. While all the others stared at me, I kept my eyes on the IO.

'Why do you want to fly in the Indian Air Force?' he asked. 'You could have also opted for civil aviation.'

'There's a lot of investment in civil aviation courses, and no job security,' I replied honestly. Civil aviation, especially private scheduled airlines in the 1990s, was still in its nascent stage in India. And the fee for a flying course was skyrocketing with every passing day. 'But if I join the Indian Air Force, I'll be commissioned in one and a half years, and that, too, as a gazetted officer of this country. Plus, I like the less-than-ordinary lifestyle in defence services.'

The IO then flipped through the pages of a file kept in front of him.

'How is your general knowledge, Ms Saxena?' he asked.

'Below average,' I replied. 'It's not good.'

'Why? Don't you listen to the news or read newspapers?' he asked.

'I read magazines, mostly about Bollywood, Sir,' I replied. Everyone smiled at my answer.

'But you must tell us something important that has been in the news currently,' the IO said. I strained my memory and tried to think.

'Umm . . . Sushmita Sen got crowned Miss Universe recently,' I replied. The IO chuckled.